

OLIVIA SAMOLEJ

630-853-3368 | Email: obs2@illinois.edu | oliviasamolej.github.io/

EDUCATION

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign
Bachelor of Science in Atmospheric Science

Expected May 2027
GPA: 3.82/4.00

SKILLS

Python, Java, Bash, Linux Terminal, Batch Computing, High-Performance Computing (HPC), Big Data Analysis, Scientific Data Processing, American Sign Language (ASL) – Proficient

RELEVANT COURSEWORK

Climate Processes, Cloud Physics, Atmospheric Thermodynamics, Atmospheric Dynamics, Synoptic-Dynamic Weather Analysis, Differential Equations, University Physics: Mechanics, University Physics: Electricity and Magnetism, Calculus, Intro to Computer Science

EXPERIENCE

Geophysical Fluid Dynamics Laboratory

Hollings Scholar Researcher

Princeton, NJ
January 2026 – Present

Research Advisor: Dr. Veeshan Narinesingh, Dr. Shiv Priyam Raghuraman

- Investigated the role of quasi-stationary waves (QSWs) in driving temperature extremes, including heatwaves and cold spells
- Implemented a Fourier and Hilbert Transform algorithm to track QSWs in reanalysis and large ensemble climate simulations of varying atmospheric and oceanic resolution
- Developed bootstrapping algorithm to test for significant biases between models and reanalysis, and for changes in QSW envelope amplitude in SSP245 and SSP585 projections
- Key Finding: QSW biases are insensitive to model resolution but future projections are

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Teaching Assistant ATMS 120 – Severe and Hazardous Weather

Champaign, IL
August 2025 - Present

- Assisted with teaching and grading in a course with over 500 students
- Explained and communicated complex mathematical concepts to the general campus population
- Held frequent office hours to provide additional support and improve student understanding

University of Michigan

NSF PICASSO REU Researcher

Ann Arbor, MI
May 2025 – July 2025

Research Advisor: Dr. Jeremy Basis

- Conducted research on Antarctic ice shelves to evaluate their stability and implications for future sea level rise
- Utilized the BISICLES ice sheet model to simulate damage to the Thwaites, Pine Island, and Dotson/Crosson ice shelves, comparing a linear and non-linear damage model
- Determined that the non-linear damage model more accurately captured observed ice shelf behavior

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Undergraduate Researcher

Champaign, IL
January 2024 - Present

Research Advisor: Dr. Robert Rauber, Dr. Troy Zaremba

- Quantify and understand the microphysical processes that occur at the termination of the radar bright band that is associated with melting hydrometeors within winter cyclones using data collected during the NASA IMPACTS (Investigation of Microphysics and Precipitation in the Atlantic Coast Threatening Snowstorms) field campaigns
- Analyze the rain/sleet/snow transition, determining if mesoscale circulations develop within the transition region and how those circulations impact the distribution of those 3 species of hydrometeors
- Simulate the melting-layer bright band using the Weather Research and Forecasting (WRF) model and then compare it with data from the ER2 X-band Doppler Radar, the High-Altitude Imaging nadir pointing Wind and Rain Airborne Profiler, and the nadir pointing W-band Cloud Radar System

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

ISTORM (Illinois Student Organization for Meteorology)

Champaign, IL

Treasure

August 2023 - Present

- Organized creative fundraising initiatives, raising over \$1500 in support of relief efforts for Hurricanes Milton and Helene
- Founded and led a fundraising committee, increasing member engagement and expanding organizational resources
- Represented ISTORM at UIUC's Engineering Open House, educating grade-school students about atmospheric science; awarded Best Undergraduate Research and 3rd Place for Most Engaging

CliMAS Ambassador

Champaign, IL

Undergraduate Student Ambassador

August 2025 - Present

- Guide prospective students by answering questions and offering honest insights about atmospheric science
- Lead tours of the Natural History Building and assist with recruitment events such as LAS LiftOff and the Majors and Minors Fair

AWARDS

Ernest F. Hollings Scholarship Recipient

- Ernest F. Hollings Undergraduate Scholarship recognizes outstanding students studying in NOAA mission fields April 2025

Department of Climate, Meteorology & Atmospheric Sciences Faculty Scholarship (Merit based)

Champaign, IL

- Awarded to a rising sophomore in the Atmospheric Sciences Bachelor's degree program who has demonstrated exceptional academic performance as a freshman April 2024

Dean's List

- Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2025

PRESENTATIONS

Samolej, O. Bassis, J. Modeling damage evolution across Antarctic ice shelves, School of Earth Society, and Environment Research Review, Urbana-Champaign, IL, February 2026.

Samolej, O. Zaremba, T. Rauber, R. Radar Bright Bands and Finescale Motions Near the Rain-Snow Boundary: Integrating IMPACTS Observations with WRF Simulations, CliMAS Seminar, Urbana-Champaign, IL, February 2026.

Samolej, O. Bassis, J. Modeling damage evolution across Antarctic ice shelves, 106th AMS Annual Meeting, Houston, TX, January 2026.

Samolej, O. Zaremba, T. Rauber, R. Characteristics of the Radar Bright band in Winter Storms, updated, 41st International Conference on Radar Meteorology, Toronto, CA, August 2025.

Samolej, O. Bassis, J. Modeling damage evolution across Antarctic ice shelves, PICCASO REU Research Review, Ann Arbor, MI, July 2025.

Samolej, O. Rauber, R. Zaremba, T. Characteristics of the Radar Bright band in Winter Storms, School of Earth Society, and Environment Research Review, Urbana-Champaign, IL, February 2025.